A Comparative Study of U.S. and Japanese Educators' Beliefs about Disability and Special Education Services

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Overview of the research

Research question

How do U.S. and Japanese educators characterize the role of children's relationships with their educators, peers, and parents in supporting the development of children with mild disabilities?

Definition of mild disabilities

Mild cognitive or behavioral disabilities: e.g., learning disabilities, high functioning autism, Asperger's syndrome, and Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)

Characteristics of children with mild disabilities

- They appear "normal" and healthy, and in many areas, function well.
- Their struggles are often invisible to their peers, parents, and educators.
- Their behaviors/difficulties may be misinterpreted as laziness, disobedience, disrespect, etc.
- They may be at risk for delay in receipt of appropriate services and maltreatment.

Significance

- Providing support to accommodate the special needs of **children with disabilities** is of interest to school social workers across cultures.
- Cultures vary in beliefs about "disability" & appropriate educational responses.
  - **Japan**: New special education policies and practices for children with milder disabilities implemented in 2007
    Children with mild disabilities who formerly were recognized as "slow learners" or "difficult "are now eligible to receive special education.
  - **U.S.**: Children with mild disabilities have been receiving special education for decades.
    1973 **Rehabilitation Act** (Section 504)
    1975 PL 94-142 (currently **IDEA**): Children with learning disabilities
    Autism and ADHD were added in 1990 and 1997, respectively.
- Stigma associated with disability and special education is a risk factor that must be balanced with advantages of specialized services for children with mild disabilities.
- Comparative research provides unique vantage points from which to consider strategies for enhancing our own policies/practices.

Prevalence

U.S. [2008]: 11.2% of children (ages 6-17) received special education services.

Specific Learning Disabilities	43%
Language Impairments	20%
Emotional Disturbances	7%
Other Health Impairments (including ADHD)	11%
Autism	5%

Japan [2012]: 2.7% of children (1st-9th grades) received special education services.

Intellectual Disabilities	44%
Autism/Emotional Disorders	24%
Language Disabilities	10%
Learning Disabilities	2.4%
ADHD	2.2%

Socio-cultural model of disability

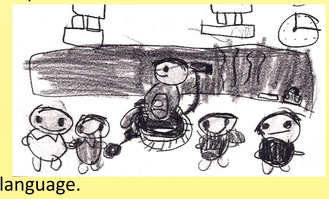
- Co-creation of the meaning of disabilities
- Disability is constructed through everyday interactions between individuals with biological/ physiological impairments and others, e.g., parents, teachers, and peers.

Methods

- Participant observations in elementary schools in the U.S. and Japan
- Individual audio-recorded interviews with U.S. and Japanese educators (on going)
- Participants described their observations of relationships between children with mild disabilities, their peers, educators, and parents.

Participants [preliminary as of December 2012]

Japan: 19 educators in 3 cities
U.S.: 22 educators in Minnesota and Illinois



Analysis

- All data were collected and analyzed in the original language.
- Using analytic induction techniques, the meanings of participants' experiences/perceptions were interpreted through repeated readings of transcribed interviews and field notes.

Results: Shared issues in the U.S. & Japan

Helping peers to support children with disabilities

Educators recognized the importance of peers. The following quotes illustrate the approaches U.S. and Japanese educators used to involve peers in supporting a child with behavior problems.

U.S. special education teacher

"What we've called 'planned ignoring', so, just let him go, don't pay attention to him, and he decides if he wants to come,..., We have little rocket dollars, that we give to children to... which they can use for things, later on... sometimes I'll give them to children who do not respond to the child because [the child was] acting out, saying, 'That's very good', you know, we don't...respond to behavior like that" and so, they get the children involved in the ignoring, planned ignoring."

Japanese classroom teacher

"I explained to them that everyone has a different amount that they are able to bear/ tolerate (*gaman*). Everyone has a cup [of tolerance], but it's different one by one. Someone has a large cup, but there is someone who has a small cup. We can't change the size of our cups easily. So, there is a person who wants to *gaman* but can't... Last year, it was a child with ADHD in first grade. When the child melted down or was upset, other children said, 'His cup has overflowed.'" (Kayama & Haight, 2012)

Children with disabilities also learn from their peers with similar struggles.

U.S. special education teacher

"I would love to see the social skill group where kids are able to, just identify with other kids to know, "Oh this is happening to somebody else, this isn't so great for them either. Because so often our elementary kids think they're on this little island, and that nobody else has ever experienced what they're experiencing, and then to be able to see, a couple of kids their own age, and no, oh yeah it's kind of rough for them right now, too."



Excerpt from field notes

Yusuke once refused to study in a special education classroom, but after spending some time together with three children from the special education classroom, his attitude gradually changed. He began to enjoy playing with them and regained his self-confidence.

Yusuke's mother's note: While watching these children and receiving energy from them, he must have learned very naturally ... that even though [they have disabilities], they can come to school and have fun. (Kayama & Haight, 2012, in press)

Building trusting relationships with children

Children's school functioning is influenced by their relationships with educators.

U.S. administrators

"We also believe that adult relationships with the students are key too, so making sure that our students know that they have adults they can go to talk about things at school, and that will be here for them and that will be listening."

"If they are really at the young ages, you have a teacher that investing you not academically but personally, I think you find a student that begins to trust them, you know let's say the academic culture, ... people here and here to help me, and you probably get more out of [it]."

Japanese classroom teacher

"I need to know about the children [in front of me]... For example, [this child] doesn't like to be treated like this, or if I do this, this child looks happy, or that kind of thing. There are many times I find I should not have said this to this child. If I say so, the child will never hear me... Therefore, I'd like to learn more about how to give them directions in a way that children are willing to hear... When this child is excited, if I say, "Can you tell me [your] story? I want to hear!" I can see the child calms down immediately, and also if I say, "It's great!" and praise him, he looks very happy and is able to work more and show progress." (Kayama & Haight, in press)

Building collaborative relationships with parents

Educators respect parents' sensitivity to stigma attached to special education.

U.S. administrator

"Our [school] counselor does a nice job, I think just be visible and let parents know when they do ask that there are people that can help... We direct them in the right way when they do ask and when they do need help, but that's well, that's really about all we can do."

U.S. school social worker

"Mom and dad aren't calling us back, we don't know what's going on. She [educator] was able to meet, sit down with them outside of the school, and we just realized that they don't have a good experience at school so they'd rather meet outside of school."

Japanese administrator

"I hadn't heard from Dai's mother for a long time. If there was no contact, I was going to call her to talk this week, but it was good I heard from her. I'd been thinking it's about time, but it doesn't work if it's too early. His mother also needed us. It shouldn't be like she had to come here because she got a call. I think it's best to talk with her when she thinks that it may be a better idea [to place Dai in a special education classroom] after she has observed her child [at school] for a long time in this support system." (Kayama & Haight, 2012)



Discussion: Cultural nuances

Both U.S. and Japanese educators recognized the importance of their relationships with children, their peers, and parents in providing support for children with disabilities. The relative importance placed on formal, structural versus informal, naturalistic support for the development of relationships, however, varied.

U.S. educators tend to emphasize the importance of formal objectives and structured programs. Their relationships with children supported these goals and objectives.

- Various programs and resources are available to teach children skills to maintain relationships; e.g., school counselors , school social workers, social skills and mentoring programs, in- and out-of-school mental health services.
- Support provided by specialists may be decontextualized.
- Support may be provided as part of legal requirements.
- Rewards/punishments are frequently used to motivate children.

Japanese education is constructed based on the assumption that children learn from their everyday, informal relationships with peers and educators.

- Educators prefer non-coercive practices and provide support for children with disabilities as "naturally" as possible in their daily activities with other children.
- Classroom teachers have broader roles with less support from specialists: They are responsible with parents for "raising" children.
- Emotional support may be prioritized.

What can we learn from each other?